Parents – A Collection

By Daniel Beaty, Perre Shelton and Sarah Kay

INTRODUCTION

When we are children, we think our parents can do no wrong. To most of us, they are superheroes who have the world completely figured out. It's not until we are older that we realize our parents are just normal people. That's when relationships with your parents get complicated, whether you are a teenager like me or a fully launched adult with children of your own.

Some of us are grieving for parents who couldn't be everything we needed as a child – grieving for the relationship we wish we could have had. Some of us have parents who were addicts, abusive, or simply absent.

No matter what type of relationship you have with your parents, I hope you can find some connection with them through these poems: Knock, Knock by Daniel Beaty, Dandelion by Perre Shelton and Hands by Sarah Kay

Knock, Knock by Daniel Beaty

As a boy I shared a game with my father.

Played it every morning 'til I was 3.

He would knock knock on my door,

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and I'd pretend to be asleep

'til he got right next to the bed,

Then I would get up and jump into his arms.

"Good morning, Papa."

And my papa he would tell me that he loved me.

We shared a game.

Knock Knock

Until that day when the knock never came

and my momma takes me on a ride past corn fields

on this never-ending highway 'til we reach a place of high rusty gates.

A confused little boy,

I entered the building carried in my mama's arms.

Knock Knock

We reach a room of windows and brown faces

behind one of the windows sits my father.

I jump out of my mama's arms

and run joyously towards my papa

Only to be confronted by this window.

I knock knock trying to break through the glass,

trying to get to my father.

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I knock knock as my mama pulls me away
before my papa even says a word.
And for years he has never said a word.
And so twenty-five years later, I write these words
for the little boy in me who still awaits his papa's knock.
Papa, come home 'cause I miss you.
I miss you waking me up in the morning and telling me you love me.
Papa, come home, 'cause there's things I don't know,
and I thought maybe you could teach me:
How to shave;
how to dribble a ball;
how to talk to a lady;
how to walk like a man.
Papa, come home because I decided a while back
I wanted to be just like you.
but I'm forgetting who you are.
And twenty-five years later a little boy cries,
and so I write these words and try to heal
and try to father myself
and I dream up a father who says the words my father did not.

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Dear Son,
I'm sorry I never came home.
For every lesson I failed to teach, hear these words:
Shave in one direction in strong deliberate strokes to avoid irritation
Dribble the page with the brilliance of your ballpoint pen.
Walk like a god and your goddess will come to you.
No longer will I be there to knock on your door,
So you must learn to knock for yourself.
Knock knock down doors of racism and poverty that I could not.
Knock knock down doors of opportunity
for the lost brilliance of the black men who crowd these cells.
Knock knock with diligence for the sake of your children.
Knock knock for me for as long as you are free,
These prison gates cannot contain my spirit.
The best of me still lives in you.
Knock knock with the knowledge that you are my son, but you are not my choices.
Yes, we are our fathers' sons and daughters,
But we are not their choices.

For despite their absences we are still here.

Still alive, still breathing

With the power to change this world,

One little boy and girl at a time.

Knock knock

Who's there?

We are.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Daniel Beaty
ISBN: 978-0316209175
Publisher: Little, Brown Books for Young Readers
Date (Month/Year): Dec 2013

AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier – This poem only
KS State Qualifier – As this program

Dandelion by Perre Shelton

she was never the beautiful, long-haired mother i wrote about in poems

she never walked barefoot through forests green blades of grass,

sheared a perfect two inches,

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one blade at a time carpeting the front lawn of her pink and white bungalow.

she just wasn't that lucky.

sunflowers and rose bushes never draped across white picket fences

her garden merely yielded curtailed dandelions polka dotted across patches of brown.

she learned to value their beauty because they had such pretty names, "dandelions."

however, she, my mother, still dreamt of sunny spring Saturdays

drenching her dreams with lemonade stands and sprinklers, heart-shaped bushes and glass Coke bottles, liberty and justice for all.

but somehow, somehow she knew better than to dream too unsilently.

as a child she would fill my days with baloney sandwiches and flavored tap water.

then, i never understood how hard she tried to keep me happy,

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and even up until today,
i have yet to discover how often she dreams.
but somehow, somehow i know it's always about me and
the husband she never had.
she was never that medallion-shaped, apron-cloaked
mistress moving proud across the wooden floor she dreamt
of
wearing almost perfectly white socks,
stretched disproportionate at the ankles from carrying life
as pure as those damn white walls
she just wasn't that lucky,

but today won't let her forget.
won't let her sink into an oblivion of white walls and pined
floors.
an oblivion of finely tuned but extremely rhythmless music.
mother, those dandelions are singing to you.

loud, boastful, brilliant.
mother, those dandelions are beautiful.
like you, but like you even they forget.
sorry they couldn't grow up amongst roses.
sorry they sprang from the cracks,

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etched in poverty America.
they grew up among society's weeds.
the neighborhood hates those dandelions,
the neighborhood wants to kill those dandelions,
but my mother always grows back.
to soak sun and hold it in her cheeks.
thin colored all-brights, brilliant yellow
and that yellow faced dandelion will never die
but she will always dream of something more than those
weeds.
until the day she realizes that a flower as beautiful as her
does not belong in a rose bush.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Perre Shelton
ISBN: On-line Transcript
https://foxthepoet.blogspot.com/2010/05/dandelion-by-perre-shelton.html
Publisher: HBO
Date (Month/Year): 2009

AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier - As this program

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Hands by Sarah Kay

(Pg 33-35) People used to tell me that I had beautiful hands.
Told me so often, in fact, that one day I started to
believe them; I started listening. Until I asked my
photographer father, *Hey Daddy, could I be a hand model?*

To which Dad laughed and said, *No way*.
I don't remember the reason he gave,
and it probably didn't matter anyway.
I would have been upset, but there were

far too many crayons to grab, too many
stuffed animals to hold, too many ponytails to tie,
too many homework assignments to write,
too many boys to wave at, too many years to grow.

We used to have a game, my dad and I, about holding hands.
We held hands everywhere. In the car, on the bus, on the street,
at a movie. And every time either he or I would whisper a
great big number to the other, pretending that we were

keeping track of how many times we had held hands,
that we were sure this one had to be eight-million,
two-thousand, seven-hundred and fifty-three.
Hands learn. More than minds do.

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Hands learn to hold other hands.
How to grip pencils and mold poetry.
How to memorize computer keys
and telephone buttons in the dark.

How to tickle pianos and grip bicycle handles.
How to dribble a basketball and how to peel apart
pages of Sunday comics that somehow always seem to stick
together.
They learn how to touch old people and how to hold babies.

I love hands like I love people. They are the maps and
compasses with which we navigate our way through life,
feeling out way over mountains passed and valleys crossed;
they are our histories.

Some people read palms to tell you your future,
but I read hands to tell your past.
Each scar marks a story worth telling. Each callused palm,
each cracked knuckle, is a broken bottle, a missed punch,

a rusty nail, years in a factory.
Now, I watch Middle Eastern hands
clenched in Middle Eastern fists.
Pounding against each other like war drums,

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each country sees their fists as warriors,
and others as enemies, even if fists alone are only hands.
But this is not a poem about politics; hands are not about politics.
This is a poem about love.

And fingers. Fingers interlocked like a beautiful accordion of flesh
or a zipper of prayer. One time, I grabbed my dad's hand
so that our fingers interlocked perfectly, but he changed his position, saying, *No, that hand-hold is for your mom.*

Kids high five, sounds of hand-to-hand combat
instead mark camaraderie and teamwork.
Now, grown up, we learn to shake hands.
You need a firm handshake, but not too tight, don't be limp now,

don't drop too soon, but for God's sake don't hold on too long.
but . . . hands are not about politics?
When did it become so complicated?
I always thought it simple.

The other day, my dad looked at my hands, as if seeing them
for the first time. And with laughter behind his eyelids,
with all the seriousness a man of his humor could muster, he said,

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You've got nice hands. You could've been a hand model.

And before the laughter can escape me,
I shake my head at him,
and squeeze his hand.
Eight-million, two-thousand, seven-hundred and fifty-four.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sarah Kay
Book: No Matter the Wreckage, Pg 33-35
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Publisher: Write Bloody Publishing
Date (Month/Year): Mar 2014

AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier - This poem, combined with Beethoven by Shane Koyczan
KS State Qualifier – As this program

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